

Exploring Cache Coherence Mechanisms: A Gem5 Simulation Study

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Abstract—Cache coherence plays a vital and crucial role in shared-memory multiprocessor systems to ensure data consistency among multiple caches. In this paper, we present an in-depth and comprehensive study of cache coherence mechanisms using gem5, a popular computer architecture simulator. We investigate various cache coherence protocols and simulated them on gem5, including directory-based and snoopy protocols, and analyze their performance characteristics in terms of latency, throughput, and power consumption. Through extensive simulations, we evaluate the impact of cache coherence on system performance and identify key factors influencing coherence protocol selection. Our findings provide valuable insights into the design and optimization of cache coherence mechanisms and protocols in modern computer systems.

Index Terms—Cache coherence, Multiprocessor systems, Gem5 simulation, Coherence protocols, Performance analysis, Power consumption, System optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

In today's digital age, the performance of computer and web servers is significant as they become increasingly integrated into our daily lives. Traditionally, efforts to enhance computer performance focused on increasing processor frequency; however, as the limitations of this approach became apparent, designers turned to alternative strategies such as increasing the number of processor cores to achieve higher performance [1]. This shift has led to the increase in use of shared-memory multiprocessor systems, where cache coherence plays a critical role in ensuring the consistency of data across multiple processor cores. Cache coherence protocols are incorporated to address the challenge of maintaining data consistency in such systems, coordinating distributed caches to provide a consistent view of memory to processors [2]. In this paper, we conduct an in-depth study of cache coherence protocols using gem5, a renowned computer architecture simulator. Our research aims to analyze the performance impact of different coherence protocols, including directory-based and snoopy protocols, on system latency, throughput, and power consumption. Leveraging gem5's simulation capabilities, we evaluate these protocols under various workload scenarios to assess their effectiveness in maintaining data consistency while minimizing overhead. Through this study, we contribute valuable insights into the design and optimization of cache coherence mechanisms in contemporary multiprocessor systems,

empowering system architects and designers to make informed decisions.

II. BACKGROUND

Cache coherence is a critical aspect of shared-memory multiprocessor systems, ensuring data consistency across multiple caches and processor cores. In this section, we delve into the intricate workings of cache coherence mechanisms and provide a comprehensive overview of the simulation framework used in our study.

A. Cache Coherence Mechanisms:

Cache coherence protocol is a solution for maintaining consistency between the shared cache block. Figure 1(a), 1(b), 1(c) and 1(d) shows briefly the coherence problem. The basic

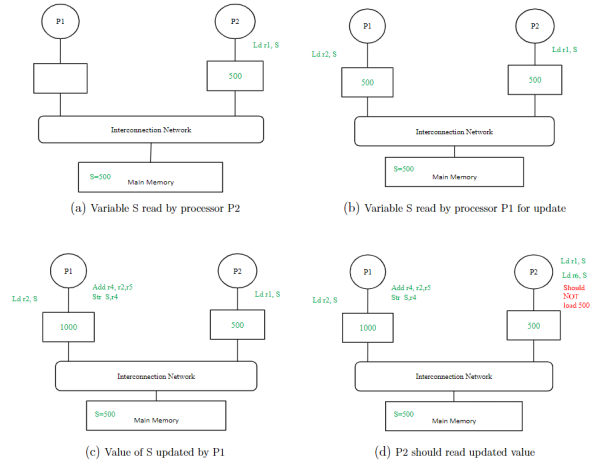


Fig. 1. Coherence Protocol

idea is that the processors should broadcast its operation to all other processors and other processors should change state of shared block accordingly. Earlier approach use two type of protocol: 1: Update and 2: Invalidate. In update protocol, when write operation is performed, a broadcast message is sent to other sharers of block, so that they update their cache block. In invalidation protocol write operation performed by one processor, broadcast invalidation message to sharers and sharers clear their shared block accordingly. There are drawbacks with

each above approaches. If data block is present in only one cache then after each update, broadcasting of “update” message is useless in Update method. Similarly if core itself do update and read operation then broadcasting invalidate message is useless in “Invalidate” method. There was requirement for proper update protocol.

Snoopy based technique developed by Goodman¹² in 1983 and Directory based technique developed by Censier and Feautrier in IEEE T_{oc}1978, are two most studied cache coherence protocols used today. In snoopy based method, a bus based communication is used to broadcast messages to other connected processors. Through bus processors observe requests/response send by other processors. For example: if P1 perform write operation on one block then the invalidate message is sent to other processors and processor sharing same block, clear its block. Figure 2, describes snoopy protocol method. Directory-Based Protocols makes use a centralized

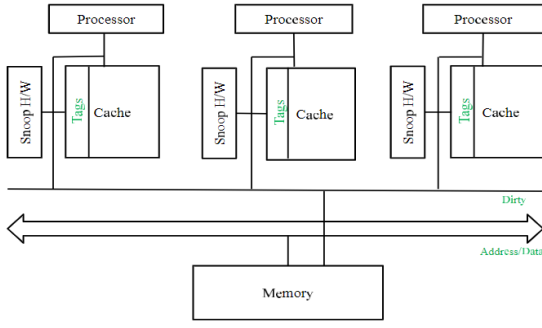


Fig. 2. Snoopy Bus Protocol

directory to maintain and keeps track of cache coherence information. The directory keeps track of which caches hold copies of each memory block and manages the permissions for accessing and modifying the blocks. Request generated by processors for a block, firstly direct the request to directory containing block. Then the directory either forwards the request or serves the request depending on state of block. Directory communication is a kind of point-to-point communication. Figure 3, describes directory method.

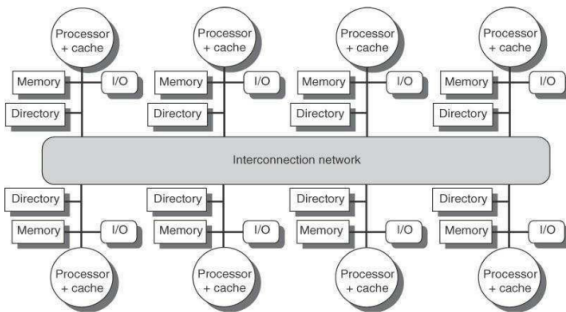


Fig. 3. Directory Based Protocol

B. Requirements for Proper coherence protocol

For any good coherence protocol there should be some important features need to be followed. Like, there should be low latency for cache to cache transfer, Bus based communication need to be avoided and a protocol should be bandwidth efficient. First, cache-to-cache transfer is very important as we prefer transfer of required data through cache-to-cache instead of transferring through main memory. Snoopy based method broadcast messages on bus, hence support low latency cache-to-cache transfer. In contrast, directory based protocol direct request to destination cache and wait for acknowledgement which takes extra clock cycle. Second, avoidance of dependency on bus like architecture as it restricts integration of more cores on the system. Directory based protocol has benefit of integrating large number of cores as here communication is point-to-point. Third, bandwidth efficiency can only be mitigated up to some level. Bandwidth need to be reduced to avoid interconnect contention, as it affects system performance. Below triangle diagram describe desirable features.

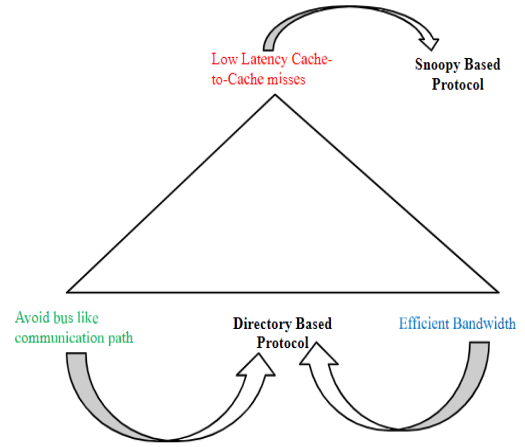


Fig. 4. Coherence Requirements

C. Simulation Framework:

To evaluate cache coherence protocols and analyze their performance characteristics, we employ gem5, a versatile computer architecture simulator renowned for its flexibility and extensibility. Gem5 provides robust support for simulating cache coherence mechanisms and multiprocessor systems, allowing researchers to conduct detailed performance analysis and experimentation. We delve into the architecture and functionality of gem5, elucidating its cache coherence models and simulation capabilities. Additionally, we discuss the implementation details of gem5’s cache coherence models, including mechanisms for coordinating cache operations and ensuring data consistency across multiple processor cores.

D. Integration and Depth:

By integrating our discussion of cache coherence mechanisms and the gem5 simulation framework, we provide readers with a comprehensive understanding of the technical

underpinnings of cache coherence analysis. This in-depth exploration sets the stage for our subsequent analysis of cache coherence protocols in the context of `ruby_mem_test` and `ruby_random_test` simulations. Through this integrated approach, we aim to equip readers with the knowledge and insights necessary to comprehend the intricacies of cache coherence and simulation-based analysis in our research.

III. SIMULATION AND ANALYSIS

In this section, we present the results of our analysis on cache coherence mechanisms using the `ruby_mem_test` and `ruby_random_test` simulations in `gem5`. Our analysis aims to provide insights into the performance characteristics of different cache coherence protocols, focusing on the comparative evaluation of time and power consumption.

A. Analysis Overview

In our analysis, we explore the behavior of cache coherence protocols across diverse workload scenarios, ranging from synthetic benchmarks to real-world applications. Through extensive simulations conducted using `gem5`, we aim to understand how different coherence protocols, including directory-based and snoopy protocols, influence system performance metrics such as latency, throughput, and power consumption.

By subjecting the system to varying workload intensities and memory access patterns, we simulate scenarios that closely mimic real-world usage conditions. This enables us to capture the dynamic behavior of cache coherence protocols under different levels of concurrency and memory contention. Through careful observation and measurement, we gain insights into how these protocols respond to varying workload characteristics and identify their strengths and weaknesses in different scenarios.

B. Comparative Evaluation:

Analysis Overview:

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Comparative Evaluation:

Our comparative evaluation reveals notable distinctions in the performance of cache coherence protocols, particularly concerning time and power consumption considerations. We

observe that the directory-based protocol demonstrates lower latency and higher throughput compared to the snoopy protocol under specific workload conditions. This is attributed to the directory protocol's centralized management of coherence information, which facilitates efficient coordination of memory accesses across multiple processor cores.

However, while the directory-based protocol exhibits superior performance in terms of time-related metrics, it incurs higher power consumption due to its centralized directory structure. The overhead associated with maintaining coherence information in a centralized directory contributes to increased energy consumption, particularly in large-scale multiprocessor systems with numerous processor cores.

Thus, our analysis highlights a trade-off between time and power consumption in cache coherence protocols. While the directory-based protocol offers advantages in terms of latency and throughput, its higher power consumption may limit its scalability and energy efficiency in power-constrained environments. Conversely, the snoopy protocol, while potentially less efficient in terms of time-related metrics, may offer advantages in power efficiency and scalability, particularly in scenarios with stringent power constraints.

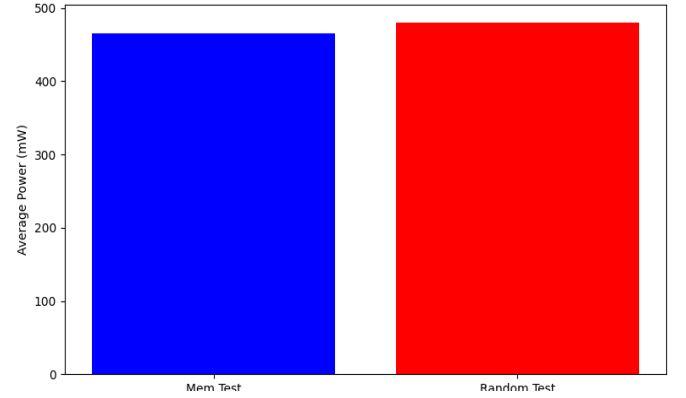


Fig. 5. Average Power Comparison

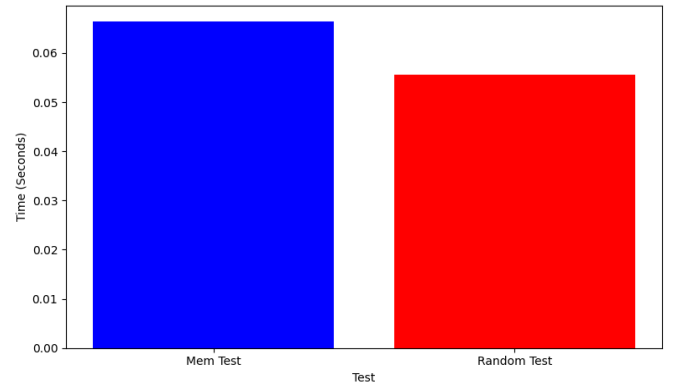


Fig. 6. Timing Comparison

C. Trade-offs and Implications

The comparative evaluation highlights the trade-offs between time and power consumption in cache coherence protocols. While the directory-based protocol offers superior performance in terms of latency and throughput, its higher power consumption may limit its scalability and energy efficiency in power-constrained environments. In contrast, the snoopy protocol demonstrates lower power consumption but may suffer from increased latency and reduced throughput in highly concurrent workloads.

D. Recommendations and Future Directions

Based on our findings, we recommend a balanced approach to cache coherence protocol selection, considering both performance and power consumption requirements. Future research efforts should focus on optimizing cache coherence protocols to achieve a balance between time and power efficiency, leveraging advanced synchronization mechanisms and architectural optimizations. Additionally, exploring novel coherence protocols tailored to specific workload characteristics can further enhance system performance and energy efficiency in multiprocessor systems.

IV. CONCLUSION

In conclusion, our analysis provides valuable insights into the performance trade-offs of cache coherence protocols in shared-memory multiprocessor systems. By evaluating the comparative impact of time and power consumption, we offer guidance for protocol selection and system optimization. Our findings contribute to the advancement of cache coherence research, paving the way for improved performance and energy efficiency in future multiprocessor system designs.

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